Exemplar essay

A literary essay on George Orwell's *Animal Farm*, by Brian Connell. As you read, **find the thesis statement**, then notice how each body paragraph proves one part of it.

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English 9
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The Silence After Snowball: How One Pig's Escape Left the Animals Defenseless in Animal Farm

Revolutions are supposed to make things better. In George Orwell's novella Animal Farm, the animals overthrow their cruel human owner, Mr. Jones, hoping to create a fair society where all animals are equal. Things go wrong quickly, however, when the pigs take over, and one pig in particular, Napoleon, becomes a dictator worse than Jones ever was. The turning point in the story comes when Napoleon's guard dogs chase Snowball, the other leading pig, off the farm. Snowball doesn't fight back or even say anything to the other animals. He just runs away and never comes back. Most readers focus on how cruel Napoleon is in this scene, but there's something else worth noticing: what disappears when Snowball leaves. When Snowball flees the farm without a fight, he leaves the common animals intellectually defenseless, exposing loyal but simple-minded creatures like Boxer and Clover to Napoleon's manipulation.

Snowball's flight from the farm happens so fast that no one has time to react. Napoleon makes a "high-pitched whimper," and suddenly nine huge dogs charge into the barn. Snowball runs. He "slipped through a hole in the hedge and was seen no more." He does not give a speech or a call to action, or make an attempt to rally the animals who had just voted for his windmill plan. Before this moment, Snowball had been the farm's big thinker, organizing reading classes, designing the windmill, and debating Napoleon in public. When Snowball spoke, the animals saw that ideas could be challenged. But in the moment that mattered most, he chose silence. Maybe running was his only choice since the dogs would have killed him. But by leaving without giving the other animals any words to hold onto, Snowball abandons them.

Without Snowball, the common animals become intellectually defenseless. Before his expulsion, Snowball had given them something they didn't even realize they needed: a voice that could push back against Napoleon. Now that voice is gone. The animals stand "too amazed and frightened to speak" after watching the attack, and that silence never really ends. They have no one to help them process what they saw or put their confused feelings into words. Orwell shows us animals who sense that something terrible has happened but lack the language to describe it or the confidence

to challenge it. The problem isn't that they're stupid. The problem is that thinking critically is a skill, and the one animal who had that skill just disappeared through a hole in the hedge.

This defenselessness hits Boxer and Clover hardest because their loyalty and simple-mindedness make them especially vulnerable. Boxer lives by two sayings: "I will work harder" and "Napoleon is always right." He's a good animal with a huge heart, but he doesn't know how to question authority. When things don't make sense, he blames his own brain rather than doubting the pigs. His loyalty, which could have powered a resistance if someone had organized it, instead flows directly to whoever holds power. Clover is a little smarter. She thinks that "these scenes of terror and slaughter were not what they had looked forward to on that night when old Major first stirred them to rebellion." She knows this isn't what they fought for. But Clover can only read four letters of the alphabet. She can feel that something has gone terribly wrong, but feeling it isn't enough to change anything.

Napoleon wastes no time exploiting this vulnerability. Immediately after Snowball's expulsion, Squealer begins rewriting history, telling the animals that Snowball "was no better than a criminal." The animals feel uncomfortable because they remember Snowball fighting bravely at the Battle of the Cowshed. Boxer even speaks up: "I do not believe that Snowball was a traitor at the beginning… He fought bravely at the Battle of the Cowshed. I saw him myself." But Squealer talks so confidently that Boxer's certainty fades. Later, Napoleon takes credit for the windmill plans that obviously belonged to Snowball. The animals sense the lie, but they can't prove it. Step by step, Napoleon erases Snowball from history and replaces the truth with his own version. Every time the animals feel doubt, Squealer explains it away, and no one can argue back.

What would have happened if Snowball had turned around at the hedge and shouted the truth to the animals? What if he had pointed at Napoleon's dogs and called them what they were: weapons of a dictator? Perhaps the animals would have risen up together, and the story would have ended differently. Or maybe the dogs would have torn Snowball apart before he finished a single sentence. We'll never know, because Snowball ran without a word. Perhaps Orwell wants us to see that bad leaders don't win just because they're strong. They win because no one is left to speak for people who can't speak for themselves. In the end, the real lesson may be that being good isn't enough to protect yourself from evil. Loyal, hardworking people who lack the ability to think critically will always be vulnerable to leaders who know how to exploit that trust.